

Family Fussy-Eater Crisis Hotsheet

Emergency Action Steps & Psychological Scripts for Table Battles, Tantrums, & Food Rejection

Introduction: The Dining Table Battlefield

Food battles are rarely about the food itself; they are about control. When a child throws a tantrum, screams, or pushes a plate away, they are testing boundaries. If parents react with anger, begging, or screen distractions, the behavior is reinforced.

This Hotsheet provides immediate, actionable response protocols and script templates to de-escalate table battles while maintaining nutritional boundaries.

Section 1: The Emergency Response Protocols

Protocol 1: The Plate Push (Immediate Food Rejection)

The Scenario: *You serve dinner, and your child immediately yells "I am not eating this!"* and pushes the plate away.*

What NOT to do: Do not cook an alternative meal (creates a habit of short-order cooking) or force them to eat.

The Protocol:

1. **Keep Calm:** Maintain a neutral expression. Do not show irritation.
2. **Neutral Statement:** Say: *"You do not have to eat it. But this is what is for dinner tonight. The kitchen will close in 30 minutes."*
3. **Leave the Plate:** Leave the plate in front of them. Continue eating your own dinner and conversing with other family members. Ignore their complaints.
4. **Clear the Table:** After 30 minutes, remove the plate without comment. If they ask for milk or cookies later, say: *"The kitchen is closed. We will have breakfast tomorrow morning."* (A healthy child will not starve from missing one meal).

Protocol 2: The Screaming Tantrum

- The Scenario:** The child screams and throws food on the floor.
- What NOT to do:** Do not scream back or offer chocolate as a bribe to stop.
- The Protocol:**
- 1. Remove the Stimulus:** Take the plate away immediately.
 - 2. Move the Child:** Gently remove the child from the dining chair.
 - 3. Use the Script:** Say: *"Food stays on the table. When you are ready to sit quietly, you can join us again."*
 - 4. Do Not Engage:** Let them calm down in a safe space. Do not make eye contact or argue during the tantrum.

Section 2: Psychological Scripting Templates

Use these exact verbal formulas to redirect power struggles:

The Child Says...	The Parent Script Response	The Psychological Reason
"This veggie looks dirty / yucky!"	"You do not have to eat it. Just leave it on the side of your plate."	Removes pressure, which reduces anxiety and encourages curiosity.
"I want Maggie / chocolate instead!"	"We can make Maggie on Saturday. Today we are eating paneer roti."	Validates their preference but maintains the parental boundary.
"I am not hungry!"	"That is fine. You can sit with us at the table and drink water."	Preserves family mealtime connection without forcing food intake.
"Make me something else now!"	"I am not a restaurant. I cooked this meal with love. We eat this."	Establishes the kitchen rule and sets healthy boundaries.

Section 3: Dining Out & Travel Survival Checklist

Eating away from home triggers sensory overload. Use this checklist to maintain control:

- [] **Never Arrive Starving:** Feed your child a small high-protein snack (like a hard-boiled egg or energy bite) 45 minutes before arriving at a restaurant. This prevents low-blood-sugar meltdowns.
- [] **Order First:** Order a simple kid-friendly side (plain roti, steamed rice, cucumber slices, or yogurt) the moment you sit down, before browsing the main menu.
- [] **The Screen-Free Rule:** Do not use phones/tablets to distract them while eating. Instead, bring a small coloring book, stickers, or toy cars to keep them occupied at the table.
- [] **Pack the Secret Boosters:** Carry a small bag of roasted seed powder or makhana in your bag. If the restaurant food lacks nutrition, sprinkle your boosters on plain rice or curd.